His energy was boundless. On 8 April, he spoke in the forenoon at the annual conference of the FICCI Ladies Organization, addressing elegant women from business families in a five-star hotel. He narrated to them the story of Jasuben's pizzas in Ahmedabad to make a case for women's empowerment. Jasuben, a Gujarati housewife, had started her own version of a pizza forty years ago. Now, her business has expanded to include six branches, with an average of 600 pizzas being sold every day in Ahmedabad. He even had a dig at Rahul Gandhi and his attempt to raise the issue of Vidarbha farm widows. 'Now, the media will think Jasuben is like Kalavati, and search for her. Let me just say that she died in Pune five years ago.' The FICCI ladies loved the free-flowing talk. 'He's just the kind of leader we need,' was the ecstatic verdict.

That same evening, Modi attended a Network 18 event which had been organized as part of a 'Think India' initiative of the network I worked for. The idea was a brainchild of Network 18 founder Raghav Bahl, who had already developed a fascination for Modi's thoughts, especially on markets and the economy. 'He is probably the only leader who is really committed to transforming the economy,' gushed Raghav. The original name for the programme was the 'Think Right' summit. I explained to Raghav that the name might send out the wrong message as we approached an election year, especially as Modi was the first speaker. Raghav was flexible—Think Right was changed to Think India. The topic for the interaction was 'Minimum Government, Maximum Governance', another pet Modi mantra.

Modi spoke passionately for an hour on a variety of issues, from speedier privatization to reducing red-tapism to reforming urban bodies: 'There is too much paperwork in government departments. Why can't this file culture be cut down?'; 'Open up the railways to the private sector'; 'We need to shift decision-making from Delhi to state capitals.' His 'can do' opinions were coming thick and fast. The entire interaction was telecast live on all the network channels (CNBC, CNN-IBN, IBN 7), including the ETV network that broadcast in half a dozen languages. The show was repeated at prime time, ensuring maximum eyeballs.